

Technical Discussions, Client Discovery & Scope Negotiation

Walking into a client conversation you do not control - and walking out with a bounded, recorded commitment.

What we'll cover

01 The discussion you do not control

02 Focused questions under pressure

03 Hearing what matters

04 Scoping a bounded first release

05 Holding the line

06 Closing the loop

07 Discovery simulation and negotiation

01

The discussion you do not control

Walking into a meeting with no agenda, no brief and no control - and still being useful.

- 01** The discussion you do not control
- 02 Focused questions under pressure
- 03 Hearing what matters
- 04 Scoping a bounded first release
- 05 Holding the line
- 06 Closing the loop
- 07 Discovery simulation and negotiation

Tuesday, 4:02 pm: “Can you join a quick client call?”

“Can someone technical join the Northgate Logistics call at 4:30? They want to talk about the tracking portal idea. That’s all I know.” - your account lead, on chat

WHAT YOU HAVE

- A company name and one vague sentence
- The walk to the meeting room to prepare
- Your technical competence

WHAT YOU DON'T

- The agenda, or who will be in the room
- What they expect you to say
- What has already been promised or decided

TWO BAD REFLEXES

Decline and hide (“I’m not client-facing”) · or walk in naked and improvise. Both cost you - there is a third way.

ASK THE ROOM *Which reflex is yours?*

What you control - and what you don't

NOT YOURS TO CONTROL

- The agenda and the attendee list
- The client's mood and internal politics
- Surprise asks and decisions already made elsewhere

YOURS TO CONTROL - ALWAYS

- **Your preparation**
- **Your questions**
- **Your record of what was said**
- **What you commit to - and the follow-up**

WEAK

"No agenda? I'll wing it - it's just a chat."

Walks in hoping the client will run the meeting. They are hoping the same about you.

STRONG

"No agenda? Then I'll bring mine."

Three things I must learn before anyone talks solutions - written down before entering the room.

THE RULE Control your four - prep, questions, record, commitments - and stop rehearsing the rest.

The ten-minute prep sheet

- **The room map** - who is coming, what each of them cares about
- **Know / Guess / Must-ask** - three honest columns
- **One goal** - what makes this meeting a success for you
- **One boundary** - what you will not commit to today

Guesses stay labelled as guesses. A guess written as a fact is how meetings go wrong quietly.

WORKED EXAMPLE - THE NORTHGATE CALL, PREP SHEET FILLED

- **Room:** Priya Nair (Ops Director - late deliveries cost her key accounts) · Ravi Menon (IT - owns the systems) · CFO “possibly” (cost scrutiny)
- **Know:** they want to discuss “a tracking portal” - nothing more
- **Guess:** a big account complained about delivery blindness (label it a guess)
- **Must-ask:** what outcome matters · what is fixed · where delivery data lives
- **Goal:** leave knowing the outcome that matters, and who decides
- **Boundary:** no feature promises, no dates - today I ask, confirm, and take away

THE RULE Ten minutes of prep beats an hour of recovery.

The first five minutes

- Name yourself and your role - one line, not a CV
- Say what you understand the meeting is for - and let them correct you
- Ask what would make it useful - then confirm the time you really have

WEAK

(SMALL TALK *drifts for six minutes)*

YOU “So... what did you want to discuss?”

PRIYA “Well - we hoped you’d tell us what’s possible.”

RESULT *You demo everything, learn nothing, and the CFO leaves early.*

STRONG

YOU “Before we dive in - I’m Asha, from the platform team. I understand delivery tracking is on your mind. What would make this half-hour genuinely useful?”

PRIYA “Honestly? Knowing if this is a quarter’s work or a year’s.”

YOU “Then let’s spend the time on what drives that answer. I have three questions.”

THE RULE If nobody frames the meeting, frame it: purpose, people, time.

Prep sprint: the Northgate call

YOUR BRIEFING - THIS IS ALL YOU GET

“Can someone technical join the Northgate Logistics call at 4:30? Priya Nair (Ops Director) asked for it. Ravi Menon from their IT will join; possibly their CFO. They want to talk about the tracking portal idea from last week’s intro call. That’s all I know.”

DO THIS

- **1 Rule a notebook page into the four prep blocks (as on the previous slide)**
- **2 Fill all four blocks: room map · know/guess/must-ask · one goal · one boundary**
- **3 Swap with your neighbour - steal one thing their sheet does better**

ONE ROW DONE FOR YOU

- Know: CFO “possibly” joining
- Guess: budget scrutiny is coming
- Must-ask: “What would the CFO need to see to fund a first phase?”

Work alone first, then pairs. We compare against a model sheet on the next slide.

What strong prep sheets said

A MODEL PREP SHEET FOR THE NORTHGATE CALL

- Room: Priya - outcome & speed · Ravi - integration risk · CFO - cost & proof
- Know: “tracking portal” discussion requested; intro call happened last week
- Guess (labelled!): recent late-delivery pain with a major account
- Must-ask: what outcome counts · what is fixed (date/budget) · where delivery data lives today
- **Goal: leave knowing the outcome that matters and who decides**
- **Boundary: no commitments on features or dates in this meeting**

WHAT USUALLY GETS MISSED

- **The boundary block left empty - decide what you won’t commit to before they ask**
- Guesses written as facts - keep the middle column honest
- Ten must-asks - you will get three; rank them

02

Asking Focused questions

Four lenses that turn "tell us what you need" into questions worth the client's time.

- 01 The discussion you do not control
- 02 Asking Focused questions**
- 03 Hearing what matters
- 04 Scoping a bounded first release
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Twenty questions, nothing learned

NORTHGATE, MINUTE 12

YOU “What features do you want?”

PRIYA “Everything, really - maps, alerts, reports, mobile...”

YOU “Should it have dashboards?”

PRIYA “Sure, dashboards are good.”

YOU “Dark mode?”

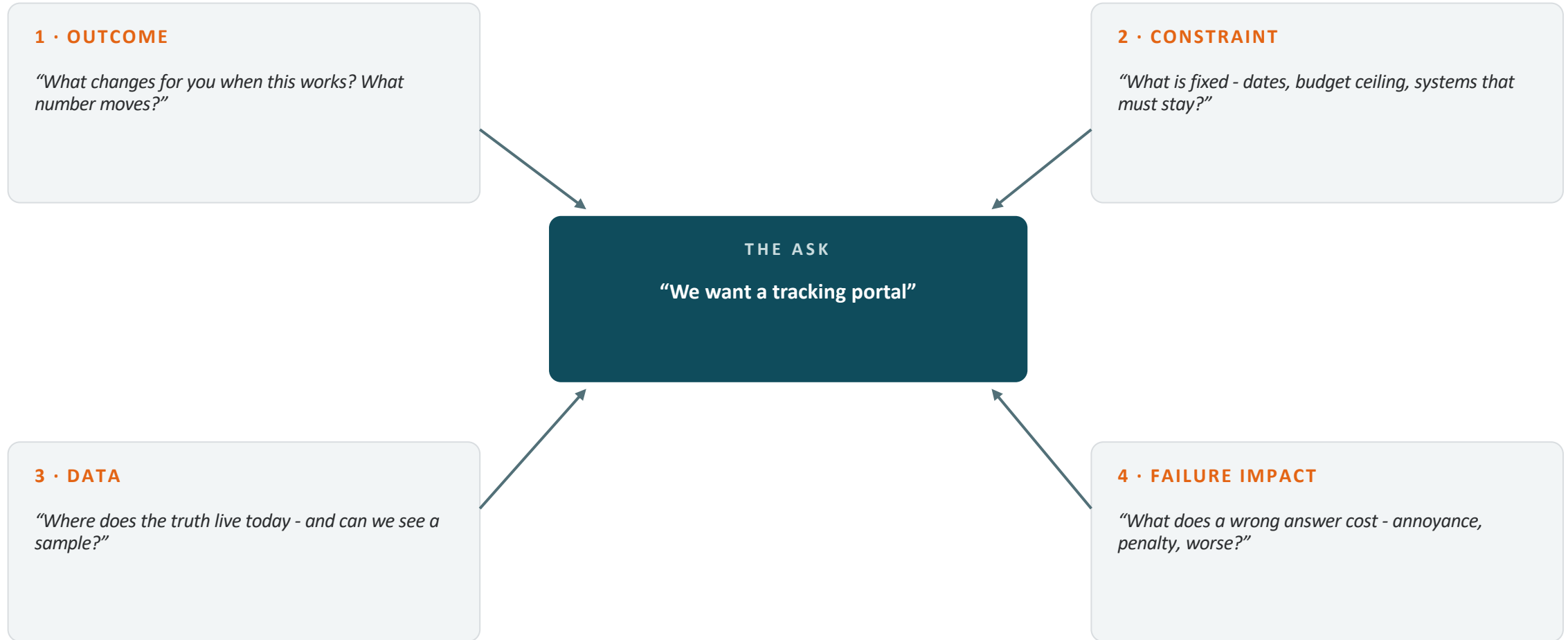
RAVI “Why not.”

WHY FEATURE-LISTING FAILS

- Every answer is “yes” - you learn no priorities
- The client is designing, you are transcribing
- Nothing you heard changes your next decision
- You leave with a wish list, not an understanding

A good discovery question is one whose answer changes what you do next.

The four lenses



THE RULE Every ask meets all four lenses before anyone talks solutions.

Outcome - ask what must change

- Feature questions collect wishes; outcome questions surface the point
- Listen for a number, a pain, or a person - not a product

WEAK

YOU “What features should the portal have?”

PRIYA “Everything, really - maps, alerts, exports...”

YIELD *A wish list. No priorities, no why. Nothing changed in what you would build first.*

STRONG

YOU “What changes for Northgate when this works? What number moves?”

PRIYA “We lose two big accounts a year to delivery blindness. Retention is the point.”

YOU “So if account managers could answer ‘where is my delivery’ instantly, that’s success?”

PRIYA “That’s exactly it.”

THE RULE Ask what must change, not what to build.

Constraint - name candidates, don't fish

- “Any constraints?” invites “not really” - a dead end
- Offer candidate constraints: dates, money, systems, people, policy

WEAK

YOU “Any constraints we should know about?”

RAVI “Not really.”

LATER *Week 3: “Oh - nothing can change during peak season. Freeze starts November 15.”*

STRONG

YOU “What’s fixed before we start - a date you can’t move, a budget ceiling, systems that must stay as they are?”

RAVI “November 15 - nothing changes in peak season. And order data stays on our existing system.”

YOU “And if a first release isn’t live by then?”

RAVI “Then honestly, we wait until January.”

THE RULE Constraints surface when you name candidates, not when you ask “any constraints?”

Data - find where the truth lives

- Where does it live today? · Who owns that system?
- How fresh is it? · Can we see a sample this week?

WEAK

YOU “Do you have the delivery data?”

RAVI “Oh yes, plenty of data.”

LATER *The “plenty” turns out to be nightly batch files owned by a telematics vendor under a restrictive contract.*

STRONG

YOU “Where does delivery status live right now?”

RAVI “GPS pings sit with our telematics vendor. Order status is on our internal order system - updated nightly.”

YOU “Who owns the vendor relationship - and could we see a sample export this week?”

RAVI “That’d be me. I can get you Thursday’s file.”

THE RULE No data seen, no estimate given.

Failure impact - price the wrong answer

- Ask what breaks when the system is wrong, late, or down
- The answer sets your quality bar - and your caution in promising

WEAK

NOBODY *(the question is never asked)*

MONTH 3 *The portal shows a confident but wrong ETA. A late delivery triggers a contractual penalty. The client asks why your system "lied".*

COST *The feature worked. The engagement still took the damage.*

STRONG

YOU "If the portal shows a wrong ETA, what breaks - an annoyed customer, a penalty, worse?"

PRIYA "Two contracts carry late-delivery penalty clauses. A wrong promise is worse than no promise."

YOU "Then accuracy beats coverage in release one. Agreed?"

PRIYA "Agreed."

THE RULE Ask what a wrong answer costs before promising a fast one.

When you only get three questions

- Pick by pending decision: which answer changes what you do next?
- Sequence: outcome first - it reprices every other question
- Park the rest out loud: “I have six more - I’ll send them in writing today”

Why data waits: its answers are verifiable offline. Outcome, constraint and failure impact only exist in the client’s head - use the room for those.

A THREE-QUESTION PLAN FOR NORTHGATE

- 1 Outcome: “What changes when this works? What number moves?”
- 2 Constraint: “What’s fixed - the November freeze, budget, systems?”
- 3 Failure impact: “What does a wrong ETA cost you?”
- *Parked in writing: data details - plus a sample-file request*

THE RULE When time is short, ask the question whose answer changes what you do next.

Sharpen six questions

SIX VAGUE QUESTIONS (NORTHGATE CONTEXT)

- 1 “What do you guys need?”
- 2 “Any constraints?”
- 3 “Is your data good?”
- 4 “What’s your budget?”
- 5 “Do you want mobile too?”
- 6 “When do you need it by?”

DO THIS

- 1 In your notebook, rewrite at least three of them
- 2 Tag each rewrite with its lens: O · C · D · F
- 3 Worked for you - #1 becomes: “What outcome would make this quarter a success for ops?” (O)

Solo, quick-fire. Model rewrites on the next slide.

Model rewrites

#	Vague	Focused	Lens
1	<i>“What do you guys need?”</i>	“What outcome would make this quarter a success for ops?”	O
2	<i>“Any constraints?”</i>	“What’s fixed - dates, budget ceiling, systems that must stay?”	C
3	<i>“Is your data good?”</i>	“Where does delivery status live, and how fresh is it there?”	D
4	<i>“What’s your budget?”</i>	“What first investment could you defend to your CFO?”	C
5	<i>“Do you want mobile too?”</i>	“Who needs the answer ‘where is my delivery’ - and where are they when they need it?”	O
6	<i>“When do you need it by?”</i>	“What happens on the day this arrives late?”	F

Notice: every focused version earns an answer you can act on - a priority, a boundary, a fact to verify, a risk to respect.

03

Hearing what matters

What clients say, what they leave unsaid, and the difference between must and would-like.

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The pause that cost three weeks

NORTHGATE, REPLAYED

YOU “Could the portal pull status straight from your order system?”

RAVI (pause) “We’d have to look at access. It’s... an older system.”

YOU “Great, sounds doable. Next question...”

THREE WEEKS LATER

- The “older system” needs a change request board that meets monthly
- Access approval alone: five weeks
- The plan was built on the words - not on the pause

Clients rarely say “this worries me”. They pause, hedge, and change the subject - and the meeting moves on.

ASK THE ROOM *What was the pause actually saying?*

Signals of the unsaid

FOUR SIGNALS WORTH CATCHING

- **Hedges** - “in principle”, “should be fine”, “mostly”
 - Commitment minus the hedge is the real position
- **Pauses and topic changes** - discomfort routing around a subject
- **Minimisers** - “just”, “eventually”, “at some point”
 - “Security eventually” often means a six-week gate
- **Missing voices** - who is affected but not in the room?

TWO PROBE MOVES (SPOKEN)

NAME IT “Ravi, you paused on access - what’s behind that?”

RAVI “Honestly, changes to that system go through a monthly board.”

ABSENT VOICE “If your security team were here, what would they push back on?”

RAVI “External access to delivery data. They’ll want a review.”

THE RULE Treat hedges and silences as data - probe them before they price themselves in.

Requirement, preference, or assumption?

One test sorts them: ask “what happens if we don’t?” - consequence makes a requirement; taste makes a preference; an untested belief is an assumption.

Client statement	“What happens if we don’t?”	Verdict
“It must use order data from our existing system”	“Orders live there. Without it the portal shows nothing.”	REQUIREMENT
“The dashboard should match our brand blue”	“Nothing breaks. The brand team just prefers it.”	PREFERENCE
“Drivers will happily update status in an app”	Nobody has asked a driver. It might be true.	ASSUMPTION

- Requirements shape scope; preferences shape polish; assumptions demand a test
- Assumptions get said out loud and written down - chapter 4 shows where

THE RULE “What happens if we don’t?” sorts must from would-like in one question.

Read the transcript twice

NORTHGATE - THE FULL EXCHANGE

- 1 **PRIYA** “We want this live before peak season, obviously.”
2 **RAVI** “In principle that’s fine.”
3 **PRIYA** “Account managers are blind on late deliveries. Customers call us first.”
4 **YOU** “Could the portal pull status from your order system?”
5 **RAVI** (pause) “We’d have to look at access. It’s... an older system.”
6 **PRIYA** “The main thing is it should look professional - our brand team is picky.”
7 **YOU** “Who would need to sign off before a pilot?”
8 **PRIYA** “Just us, mostly. Procurement at some point. Security eventually.”
9 **RAVI** “As long as nothing writes to the order system directly, we should be fine.”
10 **PRIYA** “We trust you to figure out the details.”

DO THIS - IN YOUR NOTEBOOK

- 1 Mark every hedge, pause and minimiser
- 2 Classify lines 1, 6 and 9: requirement, preference or assumption
- 3 Write ONE probe question for the strongest signal
- Worked: line 2 “in principle” = hedge → probe: “What would make it more than in principle?”

Answers on the next slide.

What the transcript was really saying

SIGNALS

- Line 2 - hedge: “in principle” = unpriced conditions attached
- Line 5 - pause + hedge: legacy access is a real risk, unowned
- Line 8 - minimisers: “mostly / at some point / eventually” = two hidden approval gates
- **Line 10 - deferral: “we trust you” often means “we haven’t decided”**

CLASSIFICATIONS + BEST PROBE

- Line 1 - requirement (miss the freeze → wait till January)
- Line 6 - preference (nothing breaks; note it, don’t scope it)
- Line 9 - requirement (read-only access is a hard boundary)
- **Strong probe: “Ravi, you paused on access - what’s behind that?”**
- **Also strong: “When you say security ‘eventually’ - what does their review involve?”**

04

Scoping a bounded first release

Carving a first release everyone can believe - and saying its edges out loud.

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The everything-release

NORTHGATE'S WISH LIST, BY THE END OF THE MEETING

- 1 Live map of all vehicles 2 Real-time ETAs
- 3 Customer portal logins 4 Email + SMS alerts
- 5 Mobile apps (iOS & Android) 6 Analytics dashboard
- 7 Order-system integration 8 Driver status app
- 9 Branded design refresh 10 API for key accounts

IF YOU NOD ALONG TO ALL TEN

- Nothing ships before the November 15 freeze - so nothing ships this year
- First demo lands in month four - trust is spent before value is shown
- Ten workstreams, one team, zero proven data access
- And the client heard “yes” ten times

ASK THE ROOM *You can keep three items. Which three - and why those?*

Why the first release is small

- Value lands before the freeze - the client sees something real
- The riskiest unknown (data access) gets proven, not assumed
- Trust earned on release one buys permission for release two
- It is not “less” - it is first. Say it that way

The lens test from chapter 2 is the carving knife: outcome picks it, constraints bound it, failure impact hardens it.

WORKED EXAMPLE - TEN WISHES BECOME RELEASE 1

“Account managers can answer ‘where is my delivery’ for the top 20 accounts - on the web, from nightly data, honestly labelled as of last night.”

- Outcome-true: answers the retention pain directly
- Constraint-true: live before the November 15 freeze
- Failure-safe: no invented ETAs, no penalty exposure
- Items 1-10 stay visible - as phase-2 candidates, not casualties

THE RULE Sell the first release as the fastest safe way to learn - never as “less”.

The Release-1 canvas

IN - OUTCOMES, NOT FEATURES (MAX 4)

Status lookup by order number for top-20 accounts · web only · nightly data, labelled “as of last night” · penalty-clause accounts flagged

OUT FOR NOW - NAMED, NOT DENIED

Mobile apps · driver app · alerts · analytics · API - all phase-2 candidates, reviewed at a named date after the pilot

ASSUMPTIONS - BELIEFS WE ARE BUILDING ON

Nightly freshness is acceptable for phase 1 · the telematics contract permits our read access

DEPENDENCIES - WHAT THE CLIENT MUST DO

Sample data export by Thursday (Ravi) · security review slot booked before build starts

EXCLUSIONS - WHAT RELEASE 1 WILL NOT DO

No writes to the order system · no customer-facing logins · no accuracy SLA on ETAs yet

Filled here for Northgate - you will redraw the empty five-block grid in Activity 4, and again in the simulation.

THE RULE Scope is what is explicitly out, assumed and depended on - not just what is in.

Say the edges out loud

WEAK

PROPOSAL Slide 47, footnote 3: “assumes nightly data refresh is sufficient.”

MONTH 2 Priya discovers “nightly” in a demo, in front of her customer.

PRIYA “You never told us it wasn’t live. What else haven’t you said?”

COST The fact was written down. It still wasn’t agreed.

STRONG

YOU “I’m assuming nightly data is acceptable for phase one - if that’s wrong, I need to know today.”

YOU “This plan depends on read access to the sample file by Thursday - Ravi, is that realistic?”

YOU “Mobile apps are out of release one - parked for the phase-two review, not forgotten.”

PRIYA “Understood. Nightly works to start.”

One sentence each. Spoken, checked, then written into the follow-up (chapter 6).

THE RULE An assumption spoken today is a plan; discovered later, it is a dispute.

Carve release 1

THE WISH LIST, AGAIN

- 1 Live map of all vehicles
- 2 Real-time ETAs
- 3 Customer portal logins
- 4 Email + SMS alerts
- 5 Mobile apps
- 6 Analytics dashboard
- 7 Order-system integration
- 8 Driver status app
- 9 Brand design refresh
- 10 API for key accounts

DO THIS - REDRAW THE CANVAS

- **1 Write the IN block as outcomes - four lines maximum**
- **2 Move everything else to OUT FOR NOW with a review moment**
- **3 Add one assumption, one client dependency, one exclusion**
- **4 Script one out-loud sentence for each of those three**
- *Worked for you - IN: "status lookup by order number, top-20 accounts, web, nightly data". Spoken: "I'm assuming nightly is acceptable for phase one - if not, I need to know today."*

Teams of three. A model canvas is on the next slide.

A model canvas - and the pushback to expect

MODEL CANVAS (CONDENSED)

- **IN:** “where is my delivery” answered for top-20 accounts · web · nightly, labelled
- OUT FOR NOW: mobile, driver app, alerts, analytics, API → phase-2 review after pilot
- Assumption: nightly acceptable for phase 1
- Dependency: sample export Thursday (Ravi) · security slot booked
- Exclusion: no order-system writes · no accuracy SLA yet

THE PUSHBACK YOU SHOULD EXPECT

PRIYA “No mobile? Our field sales team lives on their phones.”

YOU “They do - that need is real. Mobile before the freeze puts the whole release at risk, so it leads phase two, reviewed on December 1. Web reaches your account managers now.”

NOTICE *Need acknowledged · reason = constraint · alternative + named date.*

05

Holding the line

Three hard moments: the unreasonable ask, the argument in the room, the pressure to promise.

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Three moments that decide trust

1

THE UNREASONABLE ASK

“We need live GPS on mobile by November.”

An eager yes here costs you January.

2

THE ARGUMENT IN THE ROOM

Priya wants real-time. Ravi says not this year.

Pick a side and you inherit their politics.

3

THE PRESSURE TO PROMISE

“Can you at least confirm a price today?”

Silence reads as yes. So does “probably”.

Each has a pattern. None requires you to be senior - only prepared.

ASK THE ROOM *Which of the three scares you most right now?*

No, with a credible alternative

- 1 Acknowledge the need behind the ask
- 2 Give the reason as a constraint, not a preference
- 3 Offer an alternative that serves the need
- 4 Invite the decision back to them

WEAK

PRIYA “We need live tracking on mobile by November.”

YOU “We’ll try our best.”

HEARD AS “Yes.” *It enters the board deck as a commitment. January is an autopsy.*

STRONG

PRIYA “We need live tracking on mobile by November.”

YOU “Peak-season visibility is the real need - agreed. Live mobile by November isn’t something I can commit to responsibly: the feed refreshes nightly today. What I can offer: nightly-accurate status on web before the freeze, plus a real-time feasibility spike in parallel. Would that serve peak season?”

PRIYA “If web is solid by then - yes.”

THE RULE Say no to the request, never to the need - and arrive with an alternative.

When the client argues with itself

- **Make both positions explicit - and legitimate**
- **Convert positions into criteria a release could satisfy**
- **If unresolvable now: park it with an owner and a date**
- **Never become the tiebreaker in their internal politics**

Facilitate, don't referee: name both needs, propose a test, let evidence arbitrate.

WORKED EXAMPLE - IN THE ROOM

PRIYA "If it's not real-time it's pointless."

RAVI "Real-time means reopening the vendor contract. Not this year."

PRIYA "You always find a reason, Ravi."

YOU "Two real needs on the table: Priya needs customer calls answered fast; Ravi needs the vendor contract untouched. Nightly data already answers most 'where is it' calls - can we measure that in the pilot, and let the number decide how hard to chase real-time?"

RAVI "I can live with letting the data decide."

THE RULE When the client argues with itself, hold the problem - not a side.

Commit without over-committing

THE COMMITMENT LADDER

- **Take-away:** “I’ll confirm by Friday” - always available, always safe
- **Conditional:** “We can do X, if Y holds” - the workhorse
- **Unconditional:** rare - only within authority you actually have
- *Every rung is a real commitment: each has a verifiable next step*

Sounds helpful, costs you later	Helpful AND safe
<i>“Shouldn’t be a problem.”</i>	“I’ll confirm by Thursday, once I’ve seen the sample file.”
<i>“We can probably squeeze that in.”</i>	“Let’s log it as a phase-two candidate for the December review.”
<i>“Yes.” (to end the silence)</i>	“Here’s what I can commit to today - and what I need to check.”

The take-away rung is not weakness - a dated “I’ll confirm” beats an undated “yes” in every client’s memory.

THE RULE Commit to the next verifiable step, not to the dream.

Rewrite the promises, then say one no

PART 1 - SIX PROMISES TO DEFUSE

- 1 “Shouldn’t be a problem.”
- 2 “We’ll try our best to hit November.”
- 3 “Yes, mobile too, probably.”
- 4 “I’m sure the data will be fine.”
- 5 “We can start Monday.” (no security review yet)
- 6 “Consider it done.”

Rewrite any three as safe commitments (ladder rungs). Worked: #2 → “A November web release is realistic if the sample file lands this week - I’ll confirm the date Thursday.”

PART 2 - PAIR ROLE-PLAY (PRINTED SCRIPT)

A (CLIENT) “So we’re agreed - live tracking, mobile apps, all by November? Can I tell my board that?”

B (YOU) Respond with the four-move no. Then swap.

A (CLIENT) “Your competitor says they’d do it in half the time.”

B (YOU) Respond without matching the promise or trashing the competitor.

Model answers on the next slide.

What made the strong answers land

MODEL REWRITES

- #1 → “I’ll confirm by Thursday, once I’ve seen the sample file.”
- #3 → “Mobile is a phase-two candidate - reviewed December 1.”
- #4 → “I’d rather verify than assume - can we see Thursday’s export?”
- #5 → “We start the moment the security slot is booked - can we book it today?”
- #6 → “Here’s what I can commit to today: the pilot scope on this canvas.”

THE PATTERN UNDER ALL OF THEM

- **The need is acknowledged, never dismissed**
- **The reason is a constraint or a fact - not a mood**
- **There is always a next verifiable step with a date**
- **And the board question got a written-follow-up promise - never a hallway yes**

06

Closing the loop

Decisions written down in the room, and the follow-up that makes them real.

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“That’s not what we agreed”

Two weeks after a good meeting, two honest people remember two different meetings.

You remember...	They remember...
A web pilot for the top-20 accounts	<i>The portal - “and you said alerts too”</i>
Sample data promised by Thursday	<i>No memory of promising anything</i>
Phase-2 review in December	<i>“Phase two starts in November”</i>

- Nobody is lying - unrecorded agreements decay into impressions
- Memory-versus-memory disputes damage the relationship even when you “win”
- The fix costs five minutes in the room and one email after it

The live decision log

- Log WHILE the meeting runs - three kinds of entry, nothing else
- Read it back in the last five minutes: “Let me read back what I have...”
- Corrections in the room are cheap; corrections by email are arguments

Type	Entry - written as agreed, not as hoped	Owner · date
DECIDED	Release 1 = web status lookup, top-20 accounts, nightly data	-
DECIDED	Accuracy beats coverage - no invented ETAs	-
CHANGED	Mobile: moved from release 1 to phase-2 review on Dec 1	-
OPEN	Security review slot - to be booked	Ravi · by Friday
OPEN	Vendor contract allows our read access?	Ravi · by Friday

THE RULE If it isn’t read back in the room, it isn’t agreed.

The follow-up that closes the conversation

- Five parts: thanks + decisions + boundary & assumptions + open items with owners + the one next step
- Within 24 hours, to everyone who was in the room

WEAK

Subject: Great meeting!

“Hi Priya - really enjoyed the discussion today. Lots of exciting ideas! We’ll get moving on our side and circle back soon.

Thanks again!”

...closes nothing, records nothing, and reads as enthusiasm without ownership.

STRONG

Subject: Northgate portal - what we agreed today

“Priya, Ravi - thank you for today. Recording what we agreed:

1. Release 1: web status lookup for top-20 accounts, nightly data, live before the Nov 15 freeze.
2. Out for now: mobile, alerts, analytics - phase-2 review Dec 1.
3. Working assumption: nightly refresh is acceptable for phase 1 - flag by Friday if not.
4. Open: Thursday’s sample export and the security slot (Ravi).
5. Next: I confirm the delivery date Friday, once the sample lands. - Asha”

THE RULE The meeting ends when the written follow-up lands, not when the call does.

Log it, then write it

THE LAST MINUTES OF A NORTHGATE MEETING

- 1 PRIYA** “So we’re doing the web version first - fine.”
2 RAVI “And nothing touches the order system until after the security review.”
3 PRIYA “But I want alerts moved up. Right after go-live?”
4 YOU “Let’s review alerts on December 1, with the phase-2 list.”
5 PRIYA “Okay - December 1 then.”
6 RAVI “I’ll chase the sample file - should be Thursday.”
7 PRIYA “And send us something on pilot cost.”
8 YOU “You’ll have a pilot quote with my follow-up.”

DO THIS - LOG, THEN DRAFT

- **1 Log every DECIDED, CHANGED and OPEN - owners and dates included**
- **2 Draft the five-part follow-up email below your log**
- **Worked row - DECIDED: web release first (line 1)**
- *Careful: line 6 “should be Thursday” is a hedge - log it honestly*

Pairs. Model log and email on the next slide.

Model log and follow-up

MODEL LOG

- DECIDED: web release first
- DECIDED: no order-system writes before security review
- CHANGED: alerts - from “after go-live” ask to Dec 1 phase-2 review
- OPEN: sample file - Ravi - Thursday (unconfirmed)
- OPEN: pilot quote - you - with follow-up

MODEL EMAIL (CONDENSED)

Subject: Northgate portal - agreed today

“Priya, Ravi - thanks for today. Agreed: web release first; no order-system writes before the security review. Changed: alerts join the Dec 1 phase-2 review. Open: sample file (Ravi, Thursday - please confirm) and pilot quote (attached here). Next step: I confirm the delivery date Friday once the sample lands.”

07

Discovery simulation and negotiation

A live client panel, an unfamiliar brief - leave with a bounded, recorded commitment.

- 01 The discussion you do not control
- 02 Asking Focused questions
- 03 Hearing what matters
- 04 Scoping a bounded first release
- 05 Holding the line
- 06 Closing the loop
- 07 Discovery simulation and negotiation**

Your client: Meridian Financial

You know Meridian - the Buy Local Bonds platform runs through this programme. Today, a new conversation begins with one email:

FROM: DEVIKA RAO • HEAD OF RETAIL DIGITAL

Subject: Buy Local Bonds - what's next

"BLB's first months have gone well, and leadership wants to move quickly on what comes next. Ideas in the air: letting investors sell their bonds before maturity, price and maturity alerts, and the CEO keeps mentioning 'something for first-time investors'. Could your team come in on Thursday? We'd like to leave that meeting with a plan we can take to the Q3 investment committee."

IN THE ROOM ON THURSDAY

- **Devika Rao - Head of Retail Digital (sponsor)**
- **Arjun Mehta - Platform Engineering Lead**
- **Shalini D'Souza - Head of Compliance & Risk**
- *All three played by your trainer*

- **The email is deliberately vague - that is the job. Three wishes, one committee date, no scope**
- **Business, technical and risk voices in one room - they will not agree with each other**

How the simulation runs



- **Prep:** your team builds one prep sheet for the Meridian meeting - room map, know/guess/must-ask, goal, boundary
- **Discovery:** teams take turns interviewing the panel; everyone else observes, scoring against the what-good-looks-like list (two slides ahead)
- **Huddle:** each team drafts its Release-1 offer as the five-block canvas on a flip-chart sheet
- **Negotiation:** present your canvas to the panel, take the pushback, keeping a live decision log
- **Every team finishes with a canvas and a decision log** - the follow-up email is written after the debrief

While you observe, you work: score each round against the four lenses.

What good looks like

THE PANEL IS LISTENING FOR

- All four lenses visited before any solution talk
- Hedges and silences probed, gently
- A bounded Release-1 offer - edges said out loud
- Disagreement facilitated, never refereed
- Commitments made rung by rung, with dates
- The log read back before time runs out

WHAT COSTS YOU THE ROOM

- Solutioning in minute two
- A date or price promised to end an awkward silence
- Taking Devika's side against Arjun (or anyone's side)
- A canvas with an empty OUT FOR NOW block
- Leaving without reading back the log

THE RULE You are judged on what you learn and bound - not on what you promise.

Debrief

- Which lens did your team underuse - and what did it cost you?
- What did the panel NOT say? Did anyone probe it?
- What did you almost over-commit to - and what saved you (or didn't)?
- Read your OPEN column aloud: does every item have an owner and a date?
- Observers: where did the room change because of one good question?

BEFORE TOMORROW MORNING

Every team sends the real thing: your five-part follow-up email for the Meridian meeting, to your trainer, by 9:00 tomorrow.

What you can do now

- 01 Walk into an unbriefed meeting with a prep sheet and a boundary
- 02 Ask questions through four lenses - outcome, constraint, data, failure impact
- 03 Hear hedges and silences, and sort must from would-like
- 04 Carve a bounded release 1 and say its edges out loud
- 05 Say no with an alternative, hold the room, commit rung by rung
- 06 Log decisions live and close the meeting in writing
- 07 **Do all six at once, under pressure, with a real client panel**

AFTER TODAY

Take it into the field

THE HABIT

The prep sheet before every client meeting - ten minutes, every time. No exceptions for “quick calls”; those are the dangerous ones.

THE COMPASS

Outcome · Constraint · Data · Failure impact. Four words on a sticky note until they are reflexes.

THE PROOF

Your Meridian follow-up email lands with your trainer by 9:00 tomorrow. That email is the day, compressed.

Thank you - see you at the next session.